

TWENTY-FOURTH NORTHERN MARIANAS COMMONWEALTH

LEGISLATURE

IN THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES

Session, 2026

H. J. R. 24-18

A HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION

To approve the Governor's request to exempt and fill essential, vacant personnel positions within the Department of Corrections, pursuant to Public Law 24-20, Section 602(a).

1 **WHEREAS,** the Twenty-Fourth Northern Marianas Commonwealth
2 Legislature enacted Public Law 24-20, also known as the Revised Appropriations
3 and Budget Authority Act of 2026; and

4 **WHEREAS,** Section 602(a) of Public Law 24-20 mandates a freeze on
5 filling new or vacant positions within the Executive Branch, except for positions
6 essential to the delivery of public services; and

7 **WHEREAS,** Section 602(a) explicitly permits exceptions for other
8 essential positions as determined by the Governor and formally approved by the
9 Legislature via a joint resolution; and

10 **WHEREAS,** the Department of Corrections bears the critical constitutional
11 and statutory responsibility of maintaining public safety, institutional security, and
12 the comprehensive care, custody, and rehabilitation of incarcerated individuals
13 within the Commonwealth; and

1 **WHEREAS**, persistent staffing vacancies within the Department of
2 Corrections severely impact operational safety, increase mandatory overtime costs,
3 and compromise the security of both the institutional staff and the general public;
4 and

5 **WHEREAS**, through Governor's Communication 24-170, the Governor
6 has formally certified to the Legislature that specific vacant personnel positions
7 within the Department of Corrections are absolutely essential for the continuous
8 and safe delivery of public services; and

9 **WHEREAS**, the Legislature recognizes that stabilizing the workforce of
10 the Department of Corrections is vital to ensuring safe operational environments
11 and maintaining compliance with local and federal safety mandates;

12 **NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED**, by the House of
13 Representatives of the Twenty-Fourth Northern Marianas Commonwealth
14 Legislature, the Senate concurring, that the following twenty-one personnel are
15 essential for the delivery of public service and approved by the Legislature:

16 1 Parole Program Specialist

17 20 Correction Cadets

18 **BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED**, that the Speaker of the House of
19 Representatives and the President of the Senate shall certify and the House Clerk
20 and the Senate Legislative Secretary shall attest to the adoption of this joint
21 resolution and thereafter the House Clerk shall transmit a copy to Anthony C.

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION

24-18

1 Torres, Commissioner, Department of Corrections; Natalia M. Sablan, Acting
2 Secretary, Department of Finance; Virginia C. Villagomez, Special Assistant,
3 Office of Management and Budget; Joseph M. Pangelinan, Director, Office of
4 Personnel and Management; and the Honorable David M. Apatang, Governor,
5 Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands.

Prefiled: 9/22/2024

Date: _____

Introduced by: _____

Rep. John Paul P. Sablan

Reviewed for legal sufficiency by:

House Legal Counsel

Date: 9/22/26